

TJ Collamore

Mrs. Hart

AP Literature

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When the Lofoten Winds Turned

In July of 2023, my family rented a small boat on a lake in Norway. “Rented” would be a generous word. They didn’t ask for a boating license, or if we could swim. The lady behind the counter simply took my father’s driver’s license, pointed to the steering wheel and the lever that seemed to make the boat go forward and backward. That was it. My Dad had never operated a boat before. What could possibly go wrong?

The boat was very small, more of a sheet of curved metal with a small engine than a vessel, but the weather was perfect. The sky was blue, and the huge and beautiful mountains encompassed the lake. We headed toward a remote beach, reachable only by boat. We tied our metal raft to a small dock, hiked over a saddle in the mountains, and spent a few hours exploring a massive deserted beach. It felt so free being in such an estranged area with only the people I love most. It had taken four airplane flights to get to Lofoten.

My sister went swimming in the arctic water. Suddenly the glacial cold feeling turned to burning fire, and she ran out of the ocean. She was stung by a jellyfish and her entire thigh quickly became red and swollen; she was in a lot of discomfort. We needed to head back. But just as we crossed over the saddle again, and the beautiful lake holding our little boat crested into view, we also saw very ominous clouds. We hopped back in the vessel just as it started pouring.

The waves in the brackish lake were multiple feet high, and slammed the diminutive boat toward large rocks. The boat either ignored my dad’s instructions, or more likely, he had no idea

how to operate it in such a situation. My Dad's voice, usually calm and composed, turned to a frantic yell. He slammed the capsule into reverse, causing the stern to duck very low and the bow to point to the sky. A wall of water crashed into the back of him. The engine caught, and we tore away from the rocks, with the starboard side now swinging back toward the dock as we bounced over the waves. My sister instinctively half-lunged her leg out of the boat, buffeting the impact with the dock, and then expertly pushing the capsule away from the dock. We made it away from obstacles, turned the boat around, and then frantically used our sandals to scoop out the water from our boat. We headed toward home, drenched and shaken. The weather was beautiful back where we rented the dock. We made it back, speechless. The dock lady smiled, seemingly having no idea of the weather on the other side of the lake. I cherish these memories, formed by exploring the world, taking calculated risks, and living to tell the tale. I want to make a life for myself, so I can make more memories like this with my loved ones.